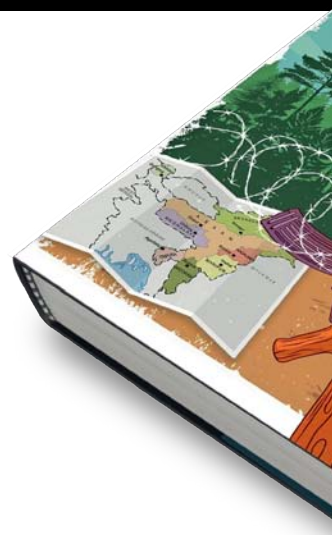
BOOKS

THE LONGEST WAR

Sudeep Chakravarti has written an accessible account of the fraught efforts to end the Naga insurgency





SUDEEP CHAKRAVARTI'S book is part-journalism, part-history, with a focus on Nagaland and Manipur, the two states central to the Naga issue

Early on in *The Eastern Gate*, author Sudeep Chakravarti visits a heroin hutch in Moreh on Manipur's border with Myanmar. Here, a "portly, jolly matron" measures out the drug from a hollowed-out bamboo bowl into a tiny metal container called *kokta*, usually used for tobacco or ground spices. Just months before his visit to this place, in February 2014, a colonel of the Indian Army and five others had been arrested on charges of ferrying pseudoephedrine tablets from Imphal to Moreh, valued at Rs 15-20 crore. The colonel's car sported defence ministry plates and a beacon. "You have heard about the arrest of a colonel," an official with a central intelligence agency later told Chakravarti in Imphal. "If he can do it at his level, then what about brigadiers, senior officers, ministers of Manipur?"

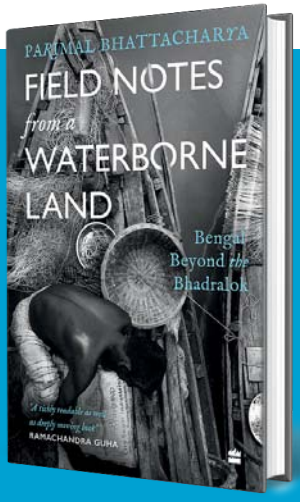
In the next chapter, we find him meeting a senior militant leader of the National Socialist Council of Nagalim's Isak-Muivah or the NSCN(I-M) faction. The former deputy chief of the NSCN(I-M) army, Ramkathing Varah, is sitting with a Walther PPK in his hands, as they have tea in the house of a mutual acquaintance who had received the handgun as a wedding gift from the group's military chief. The subject of their intense conversation is the highly contentious one of administrative autonomy for the Naga-majority hill areas of Manipur. It is this issue that has proved a major complicating factor

BOOKS

Outside City Limits

A Kolkata teacher discovers in Bengal's villages a world the *bhadralok* barely see or understand

In 2006, the Kolkata author, a college teacher, set himself a modest project of investigating the puzzle of primary school dropouts in rural West Bengal. As he explains in his preface, the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan had caught on; there seemed a change in the air. A few years later, the churning that swept out the well-entrenched Left Front also happened. He began tentatively, asking around, getting in touch with friends who travelled to the countryside—an intrepid photographer, a classmate who had given up a corporate job to run a school in a remote area, a taciturn colleague who disappeared every weekend to his village in the Sunderbans. As he travelled, Kolkata became remote. Middle-class life seemed like an apparition. The disconnect between the rural poor and the educated urbanised seemed complete.



FIELD NOTES FROM A WATERBORNE LAND: Bengal Beyond the Bhadralok
by Parimal Bhattacharya
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